

S04-L3 — The Two-Minute Pitch: History, Comparables, and Why Now

Summary. This lesson formalizes a skill Virginia already practices intuitively, presenting a specific work to a client within a short window and grounding the purchase decision in verifiable information rather than personal taste alone. The structure taught, history, comparables, and a justification for the moment, rests on documented practices among professional dealers and advisors rather than a formula invented for the course. The note develops the case used in the audio lesson, Brazilian painter Adriana Varejão, and contrasts it with Colombian sculptor Doris Salcedo to show that institutional recognition and auction price do not always move at the same pace, while adding a third case, Lygia Clark, where they did.

1. The anatomy of a sales pitch

The two-minute pitch taught in this lesson is not a pedagogical invention, it synthesizes practices already documented among secondary-market dealers. Dylan Lessel, co-director of Perrotin Second Marché, described how his team assembles a file with auction results, private-deal references, and price comparables before communicating a valuation to a client, even when the gallery itself is the buyer, so that [the client can reconstruct how the number was reached](#) rather than accepting it on faith.¹ That same logic, showing the reasoning instead of merely stating a price, is what separates a persuasive pitch from a plain description of the work.

The pitch's third component, justifying the moment, also has professional backing. London dealer Alison Jacques observed that collectors look for artists they can research and see exhibited institutionally, and directly linked [a retrospective of Brazilian artist Lygia Clark to renewed commercial interest](#) in her work.² Institutional signal, then, is not a seller's rhetorical flourish but a factor professional dealers use deliberately to argue for the timing of a deal.

2. The Varejão case, history, a recent comparable, and institutional signal

Adriana Varejão has spent more than three decades building a body of work in glazed ceramic and paint that references Brazil's colonial history, with tiles that appear to crack open to reveal a surface underneath. Her auction record was set

at Christie's London on February 16, 2011, with *Parede com incisões a la Fontana II*, hammered at GBP 1.1 million, roughly [USD 1.78 million at the exchange rate in effect at the time of sale](#).³

The comparable that anchors the audio lesson's pitch, however, is not that record but a far more recent and far more modest result, the piece *Monocromo Redondo Ge*, [sold at Phillips London on June 8, 2026 for USD 374,100](#).⁴ The choice is deliberate. A 2011 record describes what the market paid once, under conditions that no longer hold, while a result from this year describes what a real buyer is willing to pay today for a comparable piece, and it is that second figure that sustains a credible price conversation with a client in 2026.

The institutional signal completing the pitch is Varejão's participation representing Brazil at the [2026 Venice Biennale](#), the most closely watched international exhibition on the global curatorial calendar.⁵ Being selected to represent a country in Venice implies a validation process by curators, committees, and specialized press that goes beyond any single commercial transaction, and it is precisely that external validation a client cannot obtain by reading a gallery catalogue entry.

3. The limit, when institutional signal translates into price and when it doesn't

The error this lesson works to prevent is treating institutional signal as a guarantee of appreciation. The clearest contrast within the roster of artists this course has followed is Doris Salcedo, a Colombian sculptor known for installations about forced disappearance and political violence. The Whitechapel Gallery in London named her [Art Icon on March 3, 2025](#), one of the highest institutional honors an institution of that profile bestows.⁶ Despite that honor, her known public auction record sits at just [USD 665,000, in a Phillips sale with no public evidence of a recent repeat at comparably high figures](#).⁷ Salcedo's institutional recognition is as solid as Varejão's, yet her auction market remains far below it, largely because much of her output consists of large-scale installations that rarely reach the public auction circuit.

The Lygia Clark case cited in section 1, by contrast, shows the opposite scenario, an institutional retrospective that Alison Jacques directly linked to greater commercial interest.² The correct conclusion is not that institutional signal never matters or that it always matters, but that each case requires checking whether recent sales evidence accompanies the recognition, rather than assuming the correlation runs in either direction by default.

4. Building the argument without inventing certainty

The discipline of citing the most recent comparable rather than the highest one, and of explicitly separating what the evidence supports from what cannot yet be claimed, is the same discipline Carine Karam of Artsy describes when she explains that digital buyers expect to find [signals of availability, seller identity, and transparency](#) before moving forward with a transaction.⁸ Carried into a face-to-face conversation, the principle is the same, a client who can trace where each claim comes from trusts the pitch more than one who is simply asked to take the seller's judgment on faith.

For the client conversation

First, when a client asks whether a work will be worth more in the future, the professional answer separates verifiable institutional signal from a price projection, which no one can guarantee. Second, facing an artist with a thin auction history, like Varejão or Salcedo, it helps to clarify from the outset that the absence of recent comparables does not equal an absence of value, but rather a still-thin market that calls for more caution when discussing figures. Third, a pitch that cites the most recent comparable rather than the historic record builds more trust over the medium term, because it keeps a client from later discovering that the number used in conversation described an exceptional transaction rather than a current market condition.

Notes

1. Talking Galleries, *Barcelona Symposium 2022*, interview with Dylan Lessel, Perrotin Second Marché, 2022-10-03/04. [Talking Galleries](#). ↵
2. Art Basel, *Marc Glimcher: "It's not just about what's new"*, with Marc Glimcher, Alison Jacques, and Almine Rech, 2025-06-09. [Art Basel](#). ↵↵
3. The Art Newspaper, *Women artists lead the way in Brazil*, 2013-09-01. [The Art Newspaper](#). ↵
4. HENI News, *Adriana Varejão market profile*, Phillips London result of 2026-06-08. [HENI](#). ↵
5. La Biennale di Venezia, 2026 art edition. [La Biennale di Venezia](#). ↵
6. White Cube, *Doris Salcedo artist page*, Whitechapel Gallery Art Icon designation, 2025-03-03. [White Cube](#). ↵
7. Phillips, *Doris Salcedo artist page*, auction results. [Phillips](#). ↵

8. Talking Galleries, *Barcelona Symposium 2022*, interview with Carine Karam, Artsy, 2022-10-03/04. [Talking Galleries](#). ↵